

Committee: General Assembly 3

Topic: Humanitarian Action and Protection Standards in Emerging High-Tech Conflict Zones

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Introduction

Modern wars have been influenced by technologies including artificial intelligence (AI), unmanned weapon systems, drones, cyber attacks, and surveillance systems. Even though these technologies allow higher efficiency and accuracy in military force, they pose a significant danger for civilians and humanitarian agencies.

International Humanitarian Law is applicable irrespective of technology used in warfare. However, quickly progressing technologies bring up many questions concerning the protection of civilians, human control over weapon systems, liability for decisions made with the assistance of AI, and protection of hospitals and other humanitarian operations from cyberattacks. Addressing these questions has become an issue of major importance as technology is beginning to play an increasingly greater role in armed conflict.

Key Words

International Humanitarian Law (IHL) - The body of international law regulating armed conflict

Distinction - The IHL principle requiring parties to distinguish between civilians and combatants, and between civilian objects and military objectives

Proportionality - The prohibition against attacks expected to cause incidental civilian harm that would be excessive in relation to the resulting military advantage

Precautions in Attack - The requirement that parties must take feasible measures to verify targets and minimize civilian casualties

Autonomous Weapon Systems (AWS) - Weapon systems that once activated can select and engage targets without further human intervention

Military Decision-Support System - A system that processes information and provides recommendations or assessments to military decision-makers

Cyber Operation - An operation involving digital systems or networks including attempts to access, disrupt, disable or destroy computer systems, data or infrastructure

Digital Emblem - A proposed technological mechanisms intended to identify protected medical and humanitarian digital infrastructure in cyberspace

General Overview

Arising technologies are transforming how war is fought and its effect on civilians. Highly advanced technologies such as artificial intelligence (AI), autonomous weapon systems, drones, and digital surveillance are increasing military speed and precision but they also pose serious danger to the international society (RSDI, 2025). The mix of technology in military missions can make it more difficult to determine responsibility in the case of civilian injury or harm.

AI and autonomous weapons are a major concern as they could allow military systems to identify or engage targets with less human involvement. The use of advanced technology in warfare raises questions on whether these types of systems can correctly differentiate between civilians and combatants, and who is at fault when civilian deaths or injuries occur from mistakes (IDSA, 2025). Cyber warfare thus brings upon new challenges and cautions to the global table, with the risk of disrupting hospitals, electricity, water supplies and communication networks without physically destroying them.

Humanitarian organizations are also affected by technology. Aid agencies increasingly rely on digital communications and online systems to coordinate assistance and store data on population (ODNI, 2021). Due to this, cyberattacks and data breaches could interfere with humanitarian operations or put civilians under significant risk.

Though the International Humanitarian Law (IHL) currently regulates these technologies under its guidelines, there is ongoing discussion on how sufficient these rules are to keep civilians safe. The biggest challenge for the international community is to make sure that civilian protection and humanitarian access remains stable and effective while warfare becomes more and more digitalized.

Major Parties Involved

United Nations General Assembly - Provides international forum for States to discuss consequences of emerging technologies

United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA) - supports negotiations concerning emerging military technologies and responsible uses of AI in military domain

International Committee of the Red Cross

Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW)

Timeline of Relevant Events

Year	Event
1949	The four Geneva Conventions were adopted, establishing central protections for wounded soldiers, prisoners, and civilians during the case of armed conflict
1977	Additional Protocol I develops rules related to distinction, proportionality, in addition to requiring states to review new weapons for compliance with international law
1980	Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW) was adopted, providing a framework for regulating weapons that pose risks
2013	International discussions concerning lethal autonomous weapon systems start to spread within the CCW framework
2016	CCW establish a group of governmental experts on emerging technologies especially in the area of lethal autonomous weapon systems
2019	CCW discussions reaffirm a set of guiding principles, which includes the continuation of IHL across all weapons and human responsibility for decisions concerning weapon usage
2021	International debate on cyber operations increasingly recognize that existing international law applies to State use of ICT capabilities
2022	ICR technical research builds and proposes a digital emblem capable of identifying protected humanitarian infrastructure in cyberspace
2023	UN General Assembly Resolution 78/241 places lethal autonomous weapons systems on the General Assembly agenda directly
December 2025	General Assembly adopts Resolution 80/57 on lethal autonomous weapon systems
2025	The ICRC publishes research on civilian impact during digital armed conflicts
August 2026	The ICRC renews calls for international rules concerning use of advanced technology in warfare as international negotiations continue

Relevant Documents

[Geneva Convention of 1949](#)

Forms the foundation of modern international humanitarian law as well as establishing protections for wounded combatants, prisoners of war, and civilians

[Additional Protocol I to the Geneva Conventions](#)

Lays out key rules regarding distinction, proportionality, and precautions during attack

[Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons \(CCW\)](#)

Provides framework for which States can use to prohibit particular weapons

[UN General Assembly Resolution 78/241](#) - Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems

One of the first General Assembly resolutions focusing on autonomous weapons systems, expanding discussion beyond the CCW framework

Possible Solutions

1. Establish international rules and standards for the usage of AI weapons in warfare, including the requirement of states to maintain human control of AI, allowing human interference when making major decisions with potential risks involving civilians.
2. Require assessments and testings of AI systems before using AI technologies in warfare. This would allow evaluation of the system to see if it aligns with humanitarian laws and potential risks and negative impacts to civilians. Reliability and accuracy of the AI integrated weapons could also be determined before its deployment in warfare, lowering risks for unintended damage.
3. Establish international agreements on restricting autonomous and AI driven weapons, specifying when and where certain weapons may be used, under certain circumstances. Additional limitations may be set when the target is of an area with greater population, and therefore greater risk of civilian damage.

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